of the video was the simple imagery: a small Arab boy and the Ashkenazi head of state, wordlessly delivering the same message.

All of this made Rivlin, a man of the right, into a prime target for vitriol from his own political camp. One photo circulated on social media showed him in an SS uniform offering a Nazi salute. Another portrayed him in a keffiyeh, with the logo of the Palestine Liberation Organization over his right shoulder. “Reuven Rivlin is a kike traitor, may his name and memory be obliterated,” read the caption.[11] The Shin Bet was called in on various occasions to investigate threats against the president’s life.

It was another sign that the “peace process” is no longer an operative issue in Israeli politics. Peres, after all, was a universally beloved elder statesman during his presidency; he was never subjected to such criticism, even though his political views were anathema to the Israeli right. In the final year of his presidency, according to IDI, 67 per cent of right-wing Israeli Jews trusted him. Rivlin only won 55 per cent of their support in 2016. But 90 per cent of liberal Israelis had confidence in the conservative president who opposed the two-state solution that had long been the left’s defining cause.

One state, two states

Perhaps his views were irrelevant in any case: there was no peace process to speak of. The last round of US-brokered peace talks had collapsed in April 2014. It started amidst great fanfare the previous summer. Over the next nine months, Secretary of State John Kerry would hold more than 100 meetings with Netanyahu, Abbas, and their envoys. None of this work yielded much progress, however, and the talks ran aground at the end of March, when Israel refused to free a group of twenty-six Palestinian prisoners—the last tranche of four amnesties meant as “confidence-building measures”, gestures to bring the Palestinians to the table. Abbas retaliated by acceding the “State of Palestine” to fifteen international treaties—including, with no sense of irony, the UN Convention against Corruption—while Israel announced hundreds of new settler homes in the occupied territories. Kerry frantically tried to extend the late-April deadline for ending the negotiations, but his efforts failed.

It was no big surprise to the diplomats and journalists who follow the conflict. Indeed, the whole process would later be revealed as a tragic farce.